

CATCH THE RAYS
A light and shadow effect from a piece of tribal art made with wrought iron by tribals from Bastar

INDIA PICTURE

of 'symbiosis and exchange'. And empires rose from tribal communities. The Sakas, or Scythians, were horse-back archers from the Steppes. The Kushanas were the Yuezhi, from the more Sinic-flavoured borderlands of Inner Asia. The Mughals branched off from that same continuum. The Hoysalas were Malenadu tribals. Names like 'Gurjara Pratihara' or 'Pala' retain the old pastoral imprint. The Rajputs separated themselves from surrounding nomadic herdsmen with invented genealogies only in medieval times. The Siddis, of African origin, approximated to royal status in the Deccan and Bengal through centuries before being shoehorned back into 'tribal' status by the modern Indian state. Why? African, after all. The Bedas, a hunting community from Karnataka, had a similar trajectory—an illustrious martial history during the Maratha period, then relapse. Nor are any of these 'ethnicities' watertight or 'racially distinct'. The geneticist Cavalli-Sforza spoke of the Huns as a loose assemblage. Anthropologists working on India would find that familiar—people traversing imagined endogamous boundaries was the norm. Too much of the historical data speaks of humankind as a hopelessly mixed-up species, right down to community level, to satisfy *blut und boden* (blood and soil) fantasists. Heck, we even mated with the Neanderthals.

So whether you take our biology or capacity for the scientific temper, our philosophical artefacts or our material culture, we are all on the same boat—born to Neolithic Noahs, carrying memories of Old Stone Age cave art. That's why anthropologist Morton Fried asked in his 1975 classic, *The Notion of Tribe*, "Do tribes exist? Or are they chimeras, imaginary compounds of various and, at times, incongruous parts, societal illusions fabricated for diverse reasons...." In his reading, the idea of "primordial communities" does not stand up to scrutiny; they are, rather, "secondary formations" that arise among undifferentiated populations as a reaction to the formation of states and empires, who cannot be defined independently of the latter. If defining the 'self' as separate from the 'other' is a tribal act, that's what we all do. Thus it may have been those who called themselves 'arya' spoke of others as 'va-nara' ('perhaps a man') and 'kin-nara' ('what kind of man?'). The latter may have been asking the same question. ■